

ILLUSTRATIONS BY **RAHUL SHARMA/AI**

FANCY YOUR KNOWLEDGE of B-schools? Try answering this question. What is common to the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, Arizona State University, the University of Iowa, and the UK's Henley Business School? Clue: it's got nothing to do with alumni or jobs.

Here's the answer: All of them, over the past few years, have discontinued their full-time MBA programme. Why so? Applications to these schools have been on a decline for the two-year MBA, with students showing preference for shorter and more affordable options.

The tuition fee at these B-schools is around $150,000 for the full-time MBA. In good times, that was equivalent to one's first year's salary or 'cost to company'.

That equation has now begun to come apart. In the west, prior work experience is (almost) mandatory at a good B-school. For a student, it means saving up for an MBA while on a job or, in most cases, opting for a bank loan. In today's world, that monetary trade-off to keep aside two years and then get back to the job market is not compelling enough anymore.

Then, there is the big part on AI and how well-equipped a student is based on the skills he has picked up. All these factors have contributed to a scenario where the MBA